

2024

annual report

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fsd Kenya

Creating value
through inclusive finance

April 2025

Financial Sector Deepening Kenya (FSD Kenya) is an independent trust dedicated to the achievement of a financial system that delivers value for a green and inclusive digital economy while improving financial health and capability for women and micro and small enterprises (MSEs).

FSD Kenya works closely with the public sector, the financial services industry, and other partners to develop financial solutions that better address the real-world challenges that low-income households, micro and small enterprises, and underserved groups such as women and youth face.

Current FSD Kenya funders are UK International Development, the Swedish International Development Cooperation Agency (Sida), The International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), and the Gates Foundation.

FSD Kenya is part of the FSD Network, a group of Financial Sector deepening programmes seeking to build diverse and inclusive financial systems across Africa, enable inclusive growth and enhance the financial resilience and sustainable livelihoods for all.

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Every effort has been made to verify the accuracy of the information contained in this report. All information was believed to be correct as of April 2025. Nevertheless, FSD Kenya cannot accept responsibility for the consequences of its use for other purposes or in other contexts.

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A panel discussion at the warehouse receipt financing feasibility study dissemination event.
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1 Letter from **the CEO**

2024 was a remarkable year for the FinAccess Household Survey, culminating in a high-profile launch in December. This event brought together the Central Bank of Kenya, Kenya National Bureau of Statistics, FSD Kenya, various financial sector regulators, and a diverse group of financial leaders, with the Cabinet Secretary of the National Treasury and Economic Planning as our esteemed chief guest.

Our journey began even before the year started, with dedicated research teams laying the groundwork for the survey. My first deep dive into this project was alongside my enthusiastic colleagues at FSD Kenya, who volunteered to be interviewed as testers for the survey. This experience not only allowed us to provide valuable feedback to refine the survey instrument, but also deepened our understanding of how each question could reveal the realities faced by Kenyan households and how finance helps people to manage daily life, tackle risks, and invest in their dreams.

In July, I had the honour of joining the training workshop for the researchers. These amazing individuals spent the next four months being introduced by village leaders, knocking on doors, navigating dirt paths, climbing hills, and braving the weather to conduct over 22,000 interviews across Kenya's 47 counties. I emphasised to them the importance of their work, as the results would guide leaders across public, private, and financial sectors in making decisions to better serve Kenya's needs.

An even greater honour was accompanying three of these teams in rural, peri-urban, and urban areas to observe the surveys in action. The data collected was rich with insights, and the stories shared by respondents between the quantitative questions added depth to our understanding. We must acknowledge the significant time and effort given by the respondents, and we owe it to them to use this data for the greater good.

The interviews I observed showcased a broad cross-section of Kenya. I met a single mother struggling after losing her job at the local school, with the father of her child nowhere to be found. Another single mother, with her baby in arms, relied on mobile money payments from her social network to get by. At a construction site, I spoke with a man who had sold his phone to repay a debt, losing access to his mobile-money accounts and ability to access digital credit, including from the "Hustler Fund." I encountered a village leader who used diverse financial solutions to manage his farm and rural enterprises, supporting his extended family. Another farmer, with fewer resources, leased a small plot of land and supplemented his income with daily wages from working on others' farms. Lastly, I met a professor with a reliable salary, who supplemented her income with support from her extended family and loans against her predictable earnings.

These are just a few of the people behind the data we will analyse with our partners and stakeholders over the coming months. Together, we aim to better understand Kenya's inclusive financial system, identify gaps, and seize opportunities on the path towards Kenya's Vision 2030.

Tamara Cook

Tamara Cook,
Chief executive officer



2 FSD Kenya's current strategy

FSD Kenya's current strategy sets out to contribute to the development of financial markets offering useful, affordable, and trusted financial solutions for low-income households, women and Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs). Building on learnings from both FSD Kenya and the broader family of the FSD Network across the continent, FSD Kenya's work has a "real economy" focus for delivering value-adding finance.

To demonstrate how finance can work for the real economy, FSD Kenya has prioritised several sectors based on a gap analysis for women and MSEs and the potential to demonstrate the power of inclusive finance. These sectors are:

a) Agriculture and processing finance
b) Health finance
c) Affordable housing finance

As FSD Kenya engages at the intersection of the real economy and financial sector, the focus will be on shifting key functions of the financial market towards more inclusive finance. These functions of the financial market are:

Effective policy, regulation, and vision: The enabling environment has shifted towards the idea of more inclusive, digital, and greener finance, but FSD Kenya's strategy intends to walk closely with policymakers and regulators to turn those ideas into reality through the implementation of government initiatives such as the National Payments Strategy and Medium-term plans leading to Vision 2030.

Open financial market infrastructure: Although Kenya has made progress in terms of the reach and effectiveness of financial market information such as digital payments, credit information sharing and national IDs, FSD Kenya will seek to facilitate greater openness, interoperability, portability, risk mitigation, and improving financial service delivery, especially at the last mile.

Value-adding financial solutions: Given the progress in the enabling environment, financial market infrastructure and financial access, Kenya has a high possibility frontier for demonstrating how to design and deliver useful, affordable, and trusted financial solutions that help users seize economic opportunities and manage risks and shocks. Kenya already has many glimmers of promise and FSD Kenya will partner with the market to better understand when finance delivers value versus when it extracts value and then will work with the market to stimulate the scaling of value-adding financial solutions.

FSD Kenya's strategic drivers

FSD Kenya's work is guided by four strategic drivers intended to lead to greater impact from more inclusive finance:

- Positioning **gender and women's economic empowerment** at the centre of FSD Kenya's strategy
- Meeting the financial needs of **MSEs** for growth and resilience
- Leveraging the opportunities and mitigating the challenges of a more **digital economy**
- Factoring in **climate risks and green opportunities**

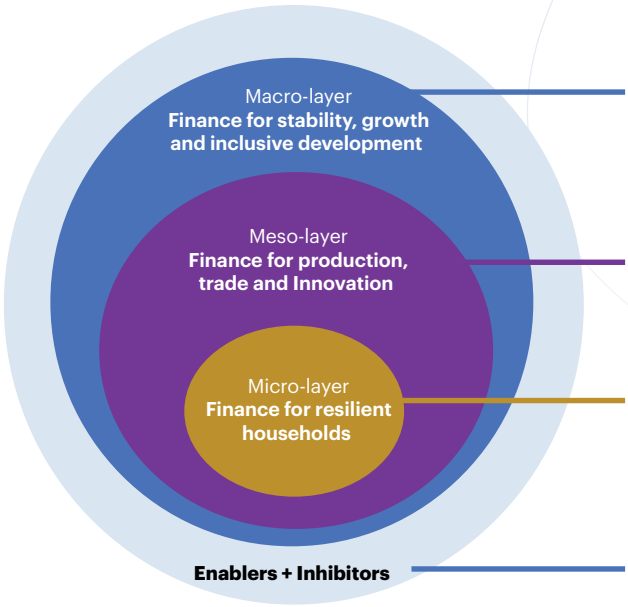
Why finance matters

Finance is an integral part of economic life and modern financial systems have enabled solutions to a range of social and economic problems, supporting welfare, growth, and development in the process.

The Government of Kenya acknowledges the role of financial services, which are a key sector in the economic pillar of Vision 2030. National objectives under Vision 2030 aim to create a vibrant and competitive financial sector driving high levels of savings and financing the country's investment needs.

The United Nations Sustainable Development Goals recognise that access to affordable, effective, and safe financial services (savings, insurance, payments, credit, and more) can play a transformative role by fostering equitable growth and furthering vital development goals such as poverty reduction, job creation, gender equality, and food security.

Why finance matters



- **Public finance**
- **Monetary policy**
- **Aggregate effects of financial intermediation**

- **Debt finance (e.g., loans, trade credit, factoring)**
- **Equity finance (e.g., venture capital, crowd funding)**
- **Informal finance (livelihoods & business)**

- **Retail finance & payments**
- **Insurance**
- **Informal finance (risk coping & basic needs**

- **Governance, policy & regulation**
- **Technology & data**
- **Social networks**
- **Business environment**
- **Social norms & values**

Understanding the role of finance, it is helpful to consider three nested layers of the economy: micro, meso and macro in the figure above.

The micro layer encompasses the individual firms and households that make up the 'atomic' units of the economy. The meso level encompasses the associations of these atomic units into more complex forms of organisation, such as firms linked together loosely in markets or sectors of production, or more tightly in value-chains; and the voluntary associations that individuals and households form such as community savings, investment, or welfare groups. Lastly, the macro layer represents economy-wide reservoirs and flows of spending power and capital residing collectively in households, government and firms and used for different ends: private consumption, government spending, investment, and international trade.

The financial system operates through each of these layers, with its effects spilling across their boundaries. At the broadest layer, finance influences how large pools of money move through the economy, and at the most granular layer, finance influences how firms and households manage money and risk and raise funds for large purchases or investments.

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The 2024 FinAccess Household Survey: Is Kenya's financial sector reaching its limits?

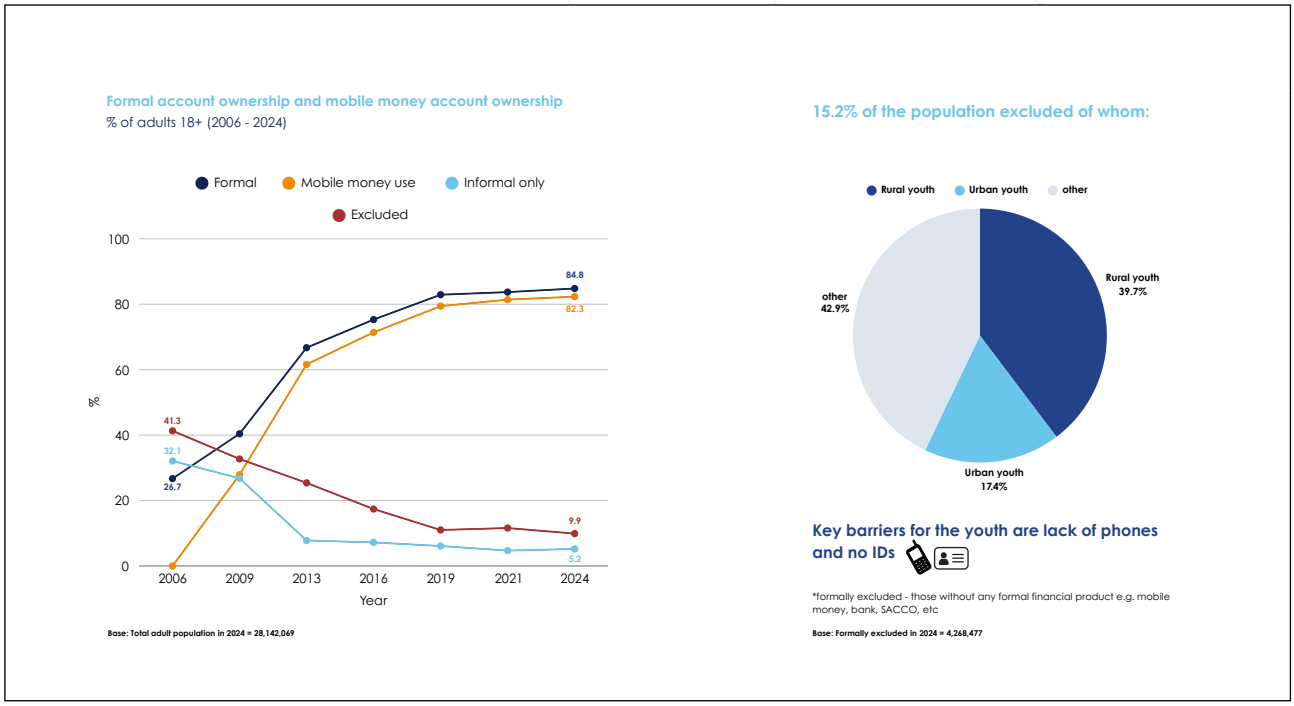


The latest FinAccess survey, launched in December 2024, reached a large audience both in person and online. The extensive media coverage of its key findings highlight's the level of public engagement in the pressing questions raised by the survey, which speak to issues at the heart of Kenya's economy and financial sector. Here, we delve deeper into the data and the critical questions it raises.

Financial Access

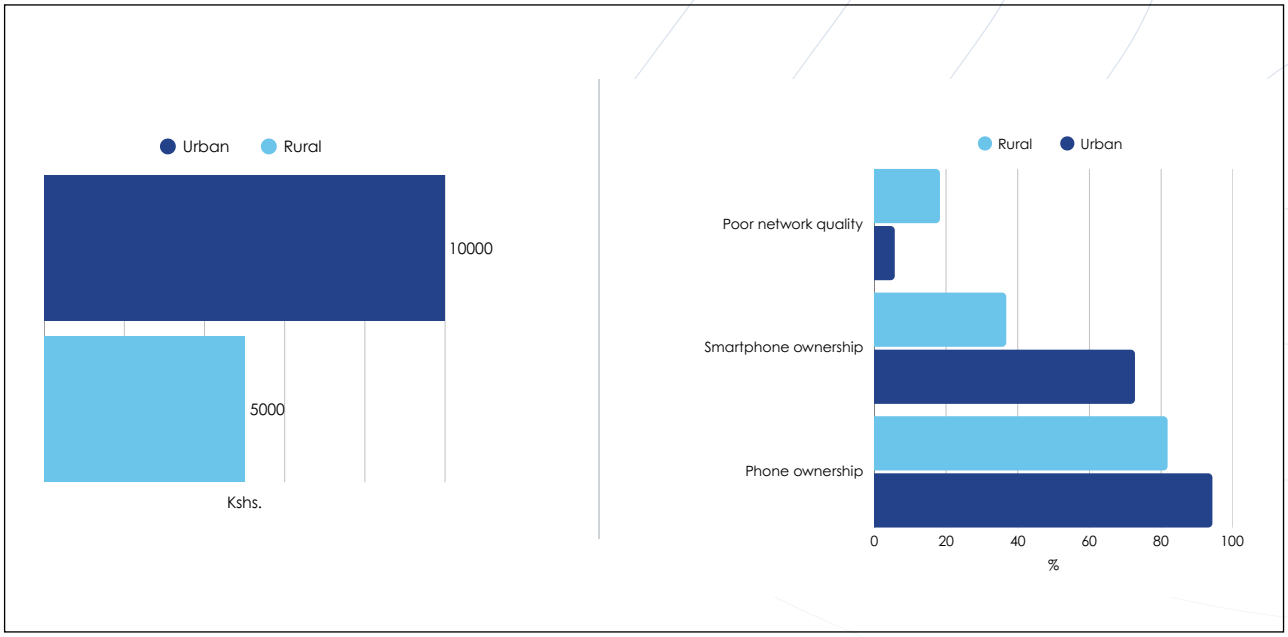
Has financial access plateau-ed? Kenya's financial inclusion growth has been underpinned by mobile money. However, flattening trendlines suggest that access has plateau-ed in recent years.

Youth and Financial Exclusion Stubborn areas of exclusion persist, particularly in rural areas and among youth aged. Nearly a third of youth aged 18-25 (who make up 57% of the excluded) do not have formal accounts. Lack of IDs are a major barrier to financial inclusion for youth; but for rural youth, the more significant barrier is lack of phones, indicating rural poverty.



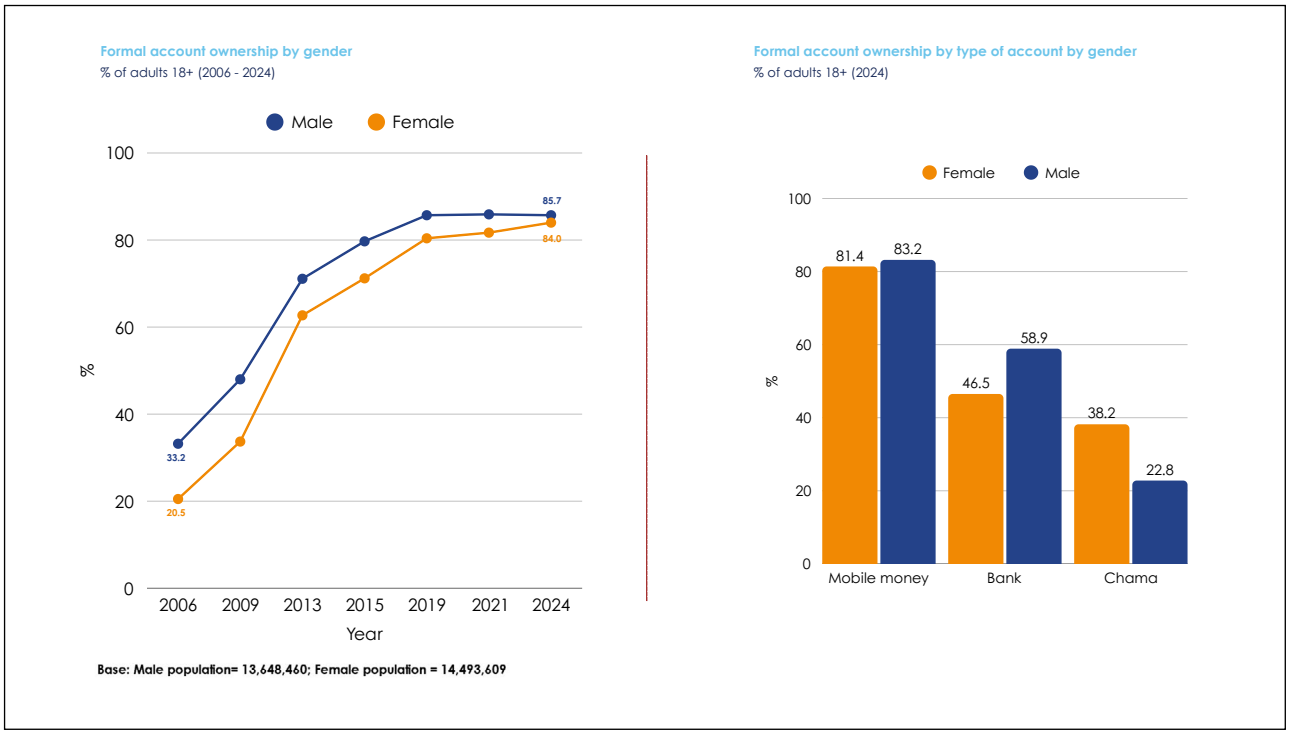
Rural/Urban Divide

Rural youth exclusion highlights a persistent rural/urban divide. As youth exclusion indicates, this is driven by rural poverty and lower levels of access to digital technology. The rural/urban divide in financial access goes hand in hand with deepening economic inequality. However, FinAccess shows that rural areas are ahead of urban areas in green investment, suggesting that investing in green development and broadening access to technology in rural areas could help bridge the divide.



Gender Gap

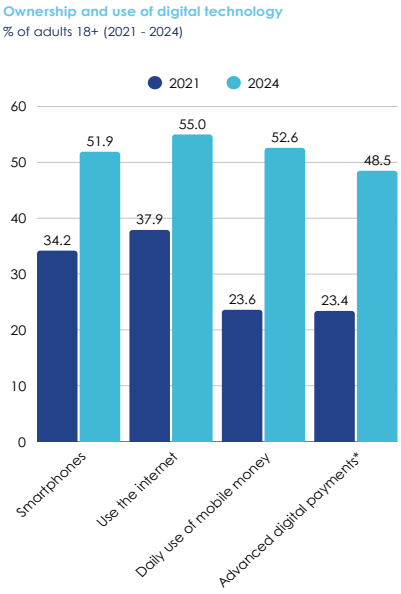
Digital technology has played a major role in reducing the gender gap in financial inclusion, which has now narrowed to 1.6%.This is significantly lower than the 6% average for developing economies. However, the parity in digital account ownership is not mirrored in access to other formal financial services. For example, only 46.5% of women have banking products compared to 58.9% of men. The gap reverses in the case of chamas (informal groups), indicating a formal/informal divide in the financing choices of women and men. How can we further close the gender gap in banking, SACCOs, pensions, insurance? Can we empower women to leverage informal finance more effectively to create bridges into the formal economy and strengthen their ability to manage day to day, cope with risk and invest in the future?

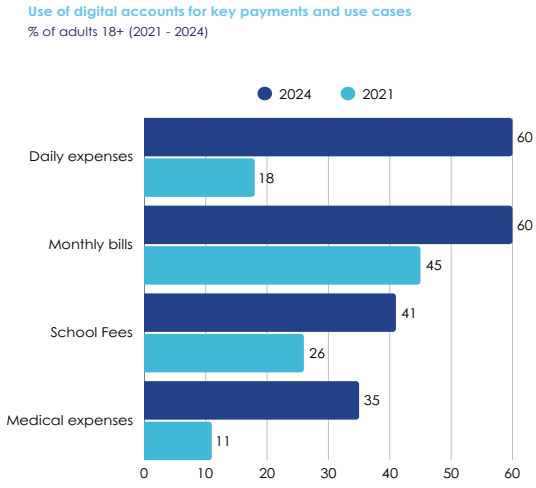


The population is becoming more digitised.

Digitisation and Financial Services

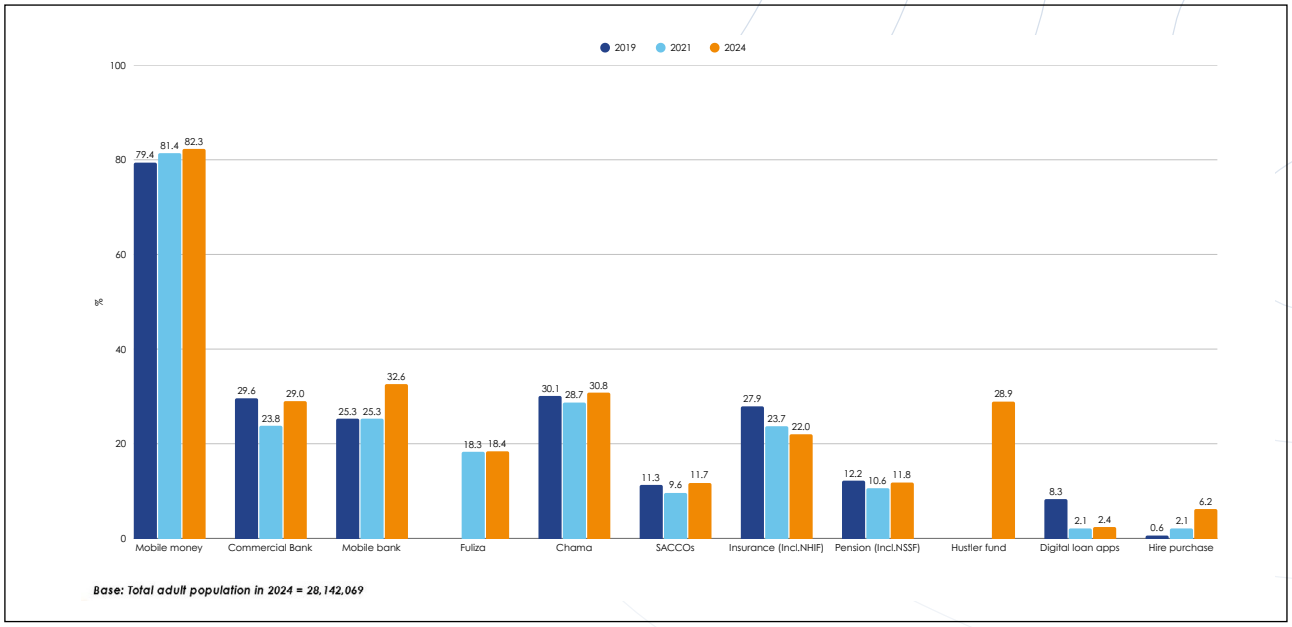
FinAccess 2024 shows a significant increase in digitisation. More people have smartphones, use the internet, and employ sophisticated payment methods such as bank till numbers which enhance information between borrowers and lenders. There has been a significant rise in use mobile money versus cash for daily needs, bills, school fees, and medical payments, and more people are receiving income digitally. Over half of all mobile money users (53%) now use their accounts daily- which translates into 44% of the adult population. How can we better leverage Kenya's digital finance to enhance wellbeing and growth by making services more affordable, empowering users with greater control over their data and financial choices, and reducing the frictions caused by concerns over increased government oversight and taxation?





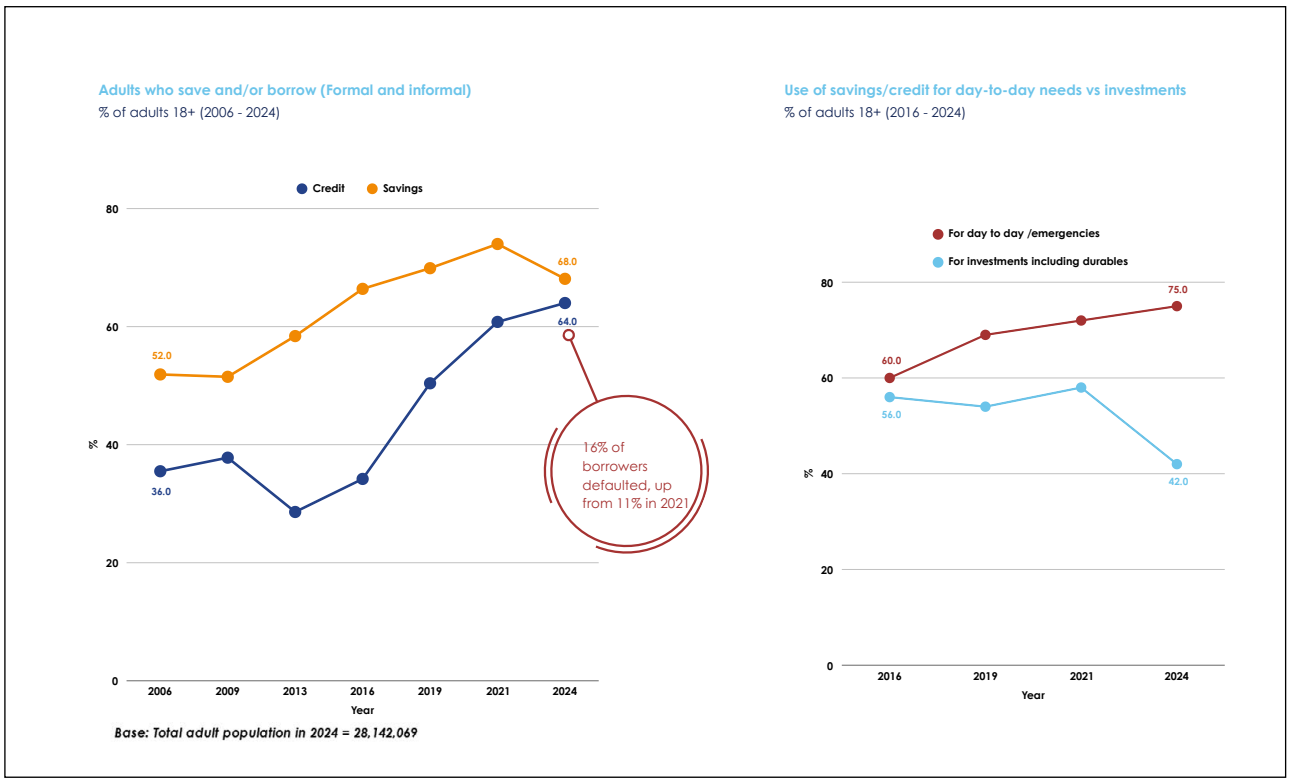
Kenya's financial landscape is diverse; but how many Kenyans have access to these products and services?

Kenya has a rich formal and informal financial landscape comprised of traditional formal services like banks, SACCOs, pensions, insurance; newer digital services like mobile banking, mobile money overdrafts (Fuliza), digital app-base finance; and a plethora of informal services from chamas to shopkeeper credit. However, since 2019 the percentage of the population using these different services has essentially remained the same, or, in the case of insurance, actually reduced. Notable exceptions include mobile banking where the percentage of users rose by nearly 7 percentage points between 2021 and 2024; and the Hustler Fund which saw a significant uptake since its launch in 2022. At the same over a third (34%) of Kenya's formally included ONLY use their mobile wallet. These users transact, borrow (e.g. Fuliza) and save on their mobile wallets, but do not use any other formal service. How can we ensure that Kenya's diverse financial sector is more accessible to all?



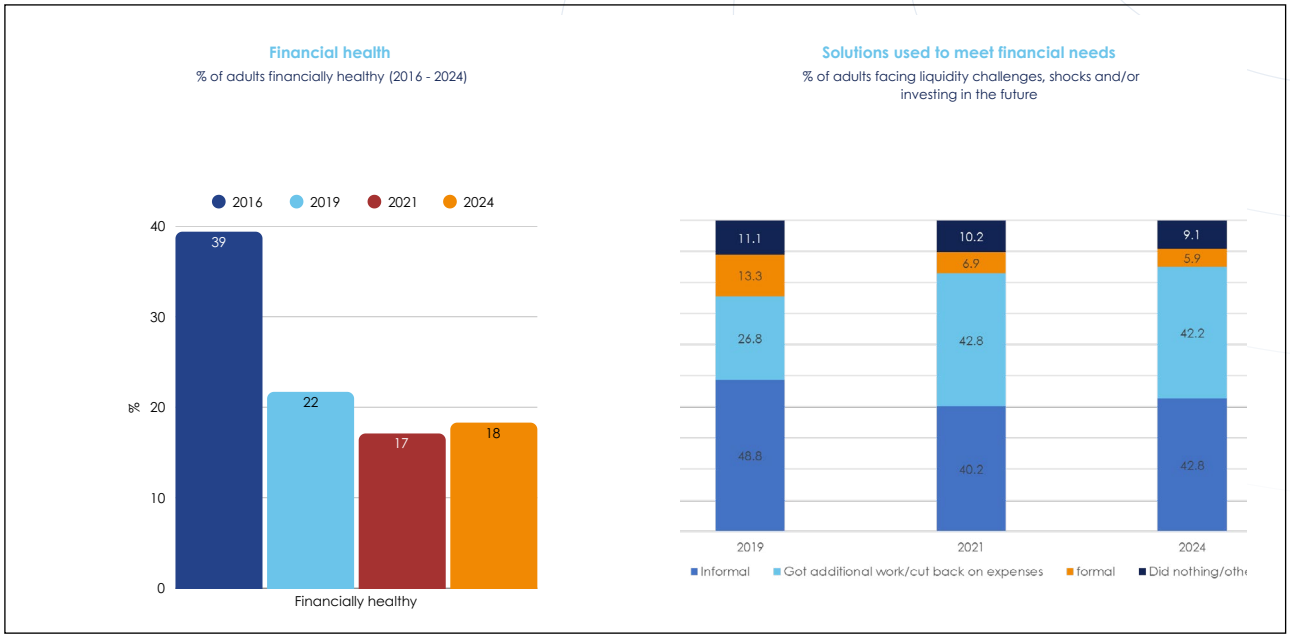
The focus of finance has shifted; prioritising daily needs over growth and investment

The percentage of the population who save has dropped for the first time since 2009. Meanwhile, a rising percentage of Kenyan borrowers are struggling to pay back loans, suggesting a growing exposure to risk. At the same time, both savings and credit are increasingly being used for daily needs and emergencies rather than investment- even for wealthier groups like MSEs and the employed. This raises critical questions: is Kenya's financial inclusion landscape encouraging borrowing at the expense of savings and thereby exposing consumers to growing levels of risk; are we sacrificing long-term growth for short-term survival; and what does this mean for financial health?



Financial Health stays low; people continue to turn to informal and non-financial strategies to meet financial needs

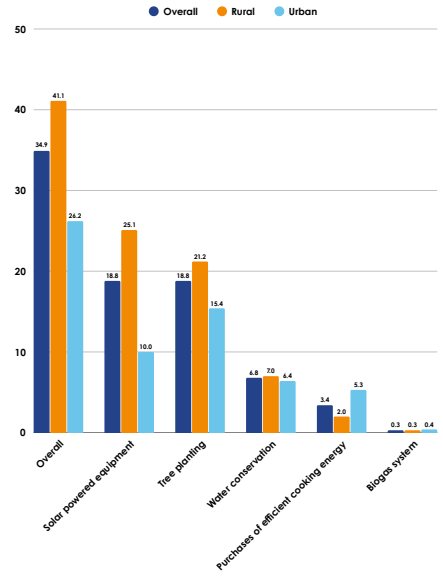
Financial health remains low at 18% of the population financially healthy compared with 84% financially included. This is partly driven by low use of formal finance to meet financial needs such as managing liquidity, dealing with shocks and investing in opportunities and goals. Instead, people continue to rely on informal strategies (especially assistance from family and friends), and non-financial strategies such as working more, to meet these needs. What kinds of partnerships are needed to enable finance to play a stronger role in boosting resilience, wellbeing and people's futures?



Green Finance

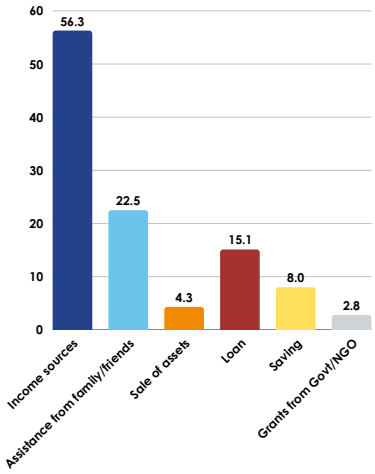
On a positive note, despite the risks and challenges they face, rural households are leading Kenya's green economy. 41% of rural residents make green investments compared with 26% of urbanites. Top green investments are in solar energy and tree planting- this is partly driven by high cost and unavailability of electricity in rural areas; urbanites are more likely than their rural counterparts to invest in efficient cookstoves. Kenyans mainly rely on their income reinvested or assistance from friends and family to finance these investments. An exception is solar energy where there is substantial reliance on loans, showing that financiers are supporting households and farms to transition towards solar. Can finance do more to support rural communities to steer the country towards a greener future?

Green investments by residence



Population=28, 072,864; *Rural population = 16,416,851, Urban population= 11,725,218;*
Solar powered equipment = 5,280,787; Tree planting = 5,264,857; Water conservation = 1,900,445; Purchases of efficient cooking = 946,536; Biogas

Source of funds for green investments



Base: Overall green investments = 9,825,257

Conclusion

Digital finance continues to drive financial access. For those with digital accounts (82%), over half use their accounts daily. Uptake of mobile banking has also increased by 7 percentage points, showing the importance of digitisation in deepening financial access beyond the mobile wallet. Digitisation has resulted in major gains for gender equality, reducing the gender divide in formal account ownership to 1.6%. However, a rural/urban digital divide still persists and youth exclusion is on the rise, with concerning implications for financial and economic inclusion.

There is a concerning shift in the use of finance for daily needs and emergencies rather than investment, indicating that finance is not driving growth effectively. Financial services which offer larger, lower-interest loans and encourage savings- such as such as traditional banks, SACCOs and chamas- reach only a small percentage of the population. This suggests that the gains in financial access brought about by digital technology are primarily focused on expanding high-volume, low-value markets for liquidity rather than innovating to expand access to financial solutions that support long-term growth and resilience. Coupled with macroeconomic conditions, this may partly explain why financial health remains low despite high levels of formal financial inclusion.

4

Highlights of **FSD Kenya's work from 2024**



A panel discussion at the Launch event of study on Kenya's credit market landscape.
Click here to read more

Towards a shared vision for open finance in Kenya



Despite the growing significance of data in the financial services sector, there has been little debate on the fundamental public policy issues related to open finance and open data interchanges in Kenya. Open finance refers to approaches to sharing consumers' financial data across providers and authorised third parties using open application programming interfaces (APIs). This seamless and open transfer and sharing of data, within set safeguards, provides the basis for developing innovative financial solutions and new business models. The United Kingdom and Brazil offer examples of markets whose financial sectors have experienced significant developments that link finance to the real economy sectors due to the application of open finance.

Open finance refers to approaches to sharing consumers' financial data across providers and authorised third parties using open application programming interfaces (APIs). This seamless and open transfer and sharing of data, within set safeguards, provides the basis for developing innovative financial solutions and new business models. The United Kingdom and Brazil offer examples of markets whose financial sectors have experienced significant developments that link finance to the real economy sectors due to the application of open finance.

FSD Kenya's work on open finance dates to the conclusion of a banking sector market enquiry by the Competition Authority of Kenya (CAK) in 2017. The enquiry recommended, among others, improvements in consumers' access and control over their financial information to facilitate innovation, competition, choice and switching. Subsequently, the National Treasury designated CAK to convene a working group to implement the enquiry's recommendations. FSD Kenya supported this process by facilitating policy roundtables and policymakers' participation in the Open Banking World Congress that was held in May 2019 in London. Whilst these efforts did not lead to tangible policy outcomes, they were instrumental in demonstrating a vision of how Kenya's financial sector can and should develop in this area.

> ***Following the roundtable, FSD Kenya, KBA and AFIK in 2024 initiated engagements with the banking and fintech sectors to assess their perspectives on open finance and identify viable use-cases for implementation.***

In 2023, FSD Kenya, the Kenya Bankers Association (KBA) and the Association of Fintechs in Kenya (AFIK) entered into a partnership to explore the potential benefits of implementing open finance in Kenya. Beyond identifying potential opportunities, the partnership sought to achieve a conception of open finance in the broader national policy agenda. The visibility and importance of this policy agenda was significantly enhanced in October 2023 when FSD Kenya hosted a policy roundtable jointly chaired by The National Treasury and Economic Planning and the United Nations Secretary-General's Special Advocate for Inclusive Finance for Development (UNSGSA). During the roundtable, it was noted that open finance could reshape Kenya's financial sector and deliver on economic and social inclusion goals. Following the roundtable, FSD Kenya, KBA and AFIK in 2024 initiated engagements with the banking and fintech sectors to assess their perspectives on open finance and identify viable use-cases for implementation.

The findings from the engagements demonstrated broad support for implementing open finance, with innovation and competition seen as the leading benefits especially in serving small businesses and the agricultural sector. In addition, open finance was seen as key in addressing current challenges in data sharing arrangements that are mainly bilateral and without standardised data sharing templates. Perhaps more significantly, industry perspectives favoured an implementation approach that is led by Kenya's policy and regulatory authorities.

The main risks perceived by the industry included slow policy processes, concerns over data security especially with smaller players and the risk that larger players will not be incentivised to participate in open data sharing approaches. A phased approach which starts with mandatory participation at the beginning for certain players was favoured.

These findings will form the basis of engagements with policymakers to broaden support for the policy proposals required to support implementation. At minimum, there should be consensus on the fundamental elements required to successfully implement open finance in Kenya.

This work demonstrates FSD Kenya's approach to market development not only as a catalyst for change but as a market facilitator that works with and through others in building a stronger evidence-based voice for policy change that favours Kenya's development aims.



The future of SACCOs and supporting low-income households



The SACCO industry continues to play an important role in the Kenyan economy through mobilisation of savings for national development and provision of credit facilities to many households. By the end of 2023, there were 357 regulated SACCOs made up of 174 Deposit Taking SACCOs (DT-SACCOs) and 183 Non-Withdrawable Deposit Taking SACCOs (NWDT-SACCOs).

Despite the difficult economic conditions brought about by the effects of Covid-19, severe droughts, high inflation and rising interest rates, the regulated SACCO industry in Kenya is growing consistently.

SACCOs face challenges in responding to a highly competitive financial sector with flexible banking platforms that can respond to the dynamic environment, sources of liquidity, and seamless integration to the National Payments System.

In 2024, FSD undertook two initiatives to support SACCOs to address some of these challenges. The first initiative involved supporting SACCO Central Kenya (SCK), a secondary SACCO established by SASRA to enable a shared services platform for SACCOs, to develop a 3-year business strategy. The aim of the shared SACCO platform is to address the challenges created by the costs associated with compliance, competition, and efficiency of SACCOs. The strategy development included studying at various markets, developing economic models, and interviewing the SACCOs, regulator, banks and Fintechs to map out what opportunities existed in the market. The strategy proposed an initial phase of shared services that includes a platform that enables a shared core banking system, facilitates inter-SACCO lending and facilitates the participation of SACCOs in national payments, amongst others. The strategy also proposed the setup of an initial core staff to operationalise SCK and support the SCK Board of Directors to implement the shared service solution. The strategy was adopted by SACCOs and is currently under the initial stages of implementation.

> ***...The aim of the shared SACCO platform is to address the challenges created by the costs associated with compliance, competition, and efficiency of SACCOs.***

The other initiative that was supported by FSD was a study to explored the 'Role of SACCOs in providing direct remittances in Kenya' since they are best placed

to reach rural population, women and low-income households. At present, SACCOs do not engage in direct cross-border remittance business largely due to various regulatory constraints. They therefore are only able to offer remittance services indirectly through partnerships or agency relationships with banks and money remittance operators. However, these partnerships have proven to be expensive and inefficient, with associated costs being passed on to end consumers or being borne by individual SACCOs. The study included interviewing various players in the remittances ecosystem including banks, money transfer operators (MTOs), SACCOs, financial sector regulators, remittance senders and receivers, etc. The findings of the study provided regulatory and operational recommendations that outlined how SACCOs can directly participate in remittances in Kenya. The next phase of this work is the formation of a task force comprised of SACCOs that are willing to provide remittances services to their customers to map out how this can be achieved as an industry.

Both of these initiatives are well aligned with the Central Bank of Kenya's initiative of developing a financial sector-wide interoperability solution that will enable instant transfer of payments across the entire financial industry, thus enabling SACCOs to participate more directly in the National Payments System. FSD Kenya will continue to support both these efforts in 2025 to ensure that the envisaged benefits are realised.



The SACCOs as remittance providers in Kenya study report launch event
Click here to read more

Green finance as a catalyst for sustainable development at county level



Green finance presents counties with a unique opportunity to unlock funding for environmentally friendly initiatives that drive socio-economic development. Recognising the role of green finance in achieving climate resilience, Kenya has made significant progress in establishing a regulatory framework to facilitate county-level access to green financing instruments. Key policies such as the Green Fiscal Incentives Policy, which leverages tax policies and subsidies to encourage sustainable practices, and the Kenya Green Finance Taxonomy (KGFT), which classifies climate-friendly economic activities, have provided a strong foundation for green investment.

Recognising the role of green finance in achieving climate resilience, Kenya has made significant progress in establishing a regulatory framework to facilitate county-level access to green financing instruments. Key policies such as the Green Fiscal Incentives Policy, which leverages tax policies and subsidies to encourage sustainable practices, and the Kenya Green Finance Taxonomy (KGFT), which classifies climate-friendly economic activities, have provided a strong foundation for green investment.

A major step in integrating green finance at the county level was the enactment of the County Climate Change Act (CCCA) by all 47 counties. This legislation mandates counties to mainstream climate action into their development plans and establish County Climate Change Funds (CCCFs) to finance local adaptation and mitigation projects. Despite these advances, the actual amount of green financing accessed by counties remains low. While the legal framework is in place, counties face several barriers, including complex regulatory requirements, limited access to diverse financial instruments, and a lack of capacity to develop investable projects. Many counties continue to rely heavily on grants rather than exploring other financing models such as green bonds, concessional loans, and blended finance. Additionally, most counties struggle with financial stability and creditworthiness, making it difficult to attract investors. Weak revenue generation and debt management further limit their ability to mobilise the necessary resources for green initiatives. These challenges were highlighted during the county green finance assessment conducted by FSD Kenya.

> ***A major step in integrating green finance at the county level was the enactment of the County Climate Change Act (CCCA) by all 47 counties.***

Recognising these challenges, the county green investment facility was established to support counties in identifying and preparing investable green projects for investment. Currently supporting 10 counties - Embu, Kirinyaga, Kisumu, Laikipia, Nairobi City, Makueni, Nandi, Taita Taveta, Vihiga, and Wajir - the facility builds on findings from the county green finance assessment conducted between October 2022 and May 2023. This assessment highlighted key investment opportunities and constraints at the county level. A major outcome of

this initiative has been the formation of County Green Investment Working Groups (CGIWG) in nine of the 10 counties. These groups, composed of technical experts from various sectors, provide a platform for counties to leverage skills from national government agencies, private sector players, and civil society to identify viable green investments.

Initial engagements with counties revealed that issuing green bonds and other debt instruments remains a significant challenge. Many counties lack adequate financial capacity and clear frameworks needed to issue debt, leading to an exploration of alternative financing options such as leasing arrangements with private investors, public-private partnerships (PPPs), and joint ventures. Grants remain a critical component of green financing, especially for projects that lack an immediate revenue-generation model but are essential for long-term sustainability. For example, building a dam to supply water for irrigation is vital for agricultural development but may not attract commercial investors without additional financial incentives. Counties participating in the County Aggregation and Industrial Parks (CAIPS) programme must also allocate budgetary resources for land acquisition and infrastructure, with matching contributions in the form of grants.

Through the County Green Investment Facility, key investment themes have emerged across the participating counties. Water management is a critical priority, with counties such as Wajir and Taita Taveta struggling to provide adequate water for domestic use. Others, like Kisumu, Nandi, and Embu, have untapped potential for small-scale hydropower projects to enhance renewable energy production. Waste management is another pressing issue, particularly in counties such as Makueni, Embu, and Kisumu, where inefficient waste collection and processing systems have led to environmental and public health challenges. Renewable energy also presents significant opportunities, especially in counties like Wajir, Taita Taveta, and Makueni, which have high solar potential but lack the capital investment required for large-scale solar farms. Additionally, agricultural counties such as Embu, Kirinyaga, Vihiga, and Kisumu are keen to invest in aggregation, value addition, and processing centres to reduce post-harvest losses and stimulate local economies. However, challenges such as duplication of projects, limited market linkages, and weak marketing strategies continue to hinder the effectiveness of these investments.

Despite the obstacles, there is growing interest among investors in county-level green projects. The facility seeks to bridge the gap between counties and investors by addressing key challenges such as technical capacity constraints, data and information gaps, and high investor risk perception. Many county officials lack adequate expertise needed to structure projects that meet investor requirements, necessitating continuous capacity-building initiatives. Additionally, most projects lack detailed feasibility studies, environmental impact assessments, and financial models, making them less attractive to investors. To address this, the facility is working with various stakeholders to fund critical assessments and studies. Investor confidence remains a major hurdle, with counties often perceived as high-risk investment destinations due to governance concerns and uncertain financial sustainability. Structuring projects through lease arrangements, special-purpose vehicles, and joint ventures can help de-risk investments and attract private sector participation.

County leadership engagement also plays a crucial role in accelerating green finance uptake. However, competing priorities and bureaucratic processes sometimes delay decision-making, slowing down project implementation. The establishment of CGIWG has helped mitigate this by delegating authority to technical teams with the capacity to make informed investment decisions. At the national level, coordination with key stakeholders such as the National Treasury and Economic Planning is essential to streamline policy and regulatory processes, ensuring that counties can efficiently access green financing mechanisms.

Unlocking green finance for counties requires a multi-faceted approach that includes strengthening technical capacity, improving project bankability, diversifying financial instruments, and fostering investor confidence. By addressing these critical areas, counties can enhance their ability to secure sustainable financing, drive climate-resilient development, and contribute meaningfully to Kenya's green growth agenda.

Concurrently, following the recent uncovering of financial fraud that took place at the Kenya Union of Savings and Credit Co-orperatives (KUSCCO), plans are underway to develop regulatory policy to supervise SCK, which was what was missing for KUSCCO.

FSD Kenya's work on green finance aims to stimulate interest and action in both 'greening finance' (mainstreaming climate and environment factors as a financial and strategic imperative in the financial sector) and 'financing green' (mobilising private and public finance for clean and resilient growth).

Click here to access more stories, blogs and publications related to FSD Kenya's green finance work

Unlocking transition finance: Making a case for agri-enterprises in Kenya's agriculture sector



In Kenya, climate-related transition risks negatively affect a myriad of meso level enterprises, especially so, within the agriculture sector. Agro processors who often deal with runaway energy bills, face limitations in accessing applicable, affordable and tailored finance when they want to transition to clean and climate resilient technologies that offer reprieve.

Consequently, on the demand side, high energy costs resulting in high(er) costs of production and lower revenues and increases in probability of default and loss given default of loan books, on the supply side. How then, do these enterprises mobilise capital to support a just transition? What role can finance play?

The Micro-Enterprise Support Programme Trust (MESPT) conducted energy audits across 15 agro-SMEs in Kenya, spread across the country's counties. These audits aimed to provide these enterprises with the knowledge and guidance to transition to climate-resilient technologies. However, two years later, the level of implementation of audit recommendations was disappointing. Many of the agri-businesses had only made modest progress and struggled with the upfront costs of implementing these changes.

In 2024, MESPT, in partnership with FSD Kenya, sought to address these challenges by working on green finance solutions specifically designed for Kenya's agricultural sector. These solutions would help create pathways for a just and equitable transition, in line with Kenya's decarbonisation goals and The Paris Agreement.

Field visits in 2024 revealed that while the enterprises understood the importance of adopting climate-resilient technologies, they were frustrated by the high initial costs of the transition. Majority of them expressed concerns over the lack of affordable, tailored financing options from financial institutions, or the absence of targeted government subsidies to support these efforts. Financial institutions, who finance these hard-to-abate sectors, also noted that they struggled to understand how to incentivise these agro-processors to adopt green solutions. They lacked the expertise and structures to develop and scale tailored green finance solutions.

This misalignment between the needs of the agro-processors and the offerings of financial institutions presented a clear barrier. The solution, as MESPT and FSD Kenya recognised, lies in bridging this gap and creating green finance models that are adaptable, scalable, and accessible for Kenya's agricultural sector.

To address these challenges, FSD Kenya and MESPT launched a green energy transmission mechanism pilot aimed at designing and testing financial solutions that could help agro-processors adopt low-carbon technologies. The goal of this initiative is multifaceted:

a) **Supporting the scaling of climate solutions** within Kenya's agricultural sector.
b) **Building capabilities** for both demand-side actors (agro-enterprises) and supply-side actors (financial institutions) to align with 1.5°C climate pathways.
c) **Facilitating transition** for value chains committed to aligning with a low-carbon future.
d) **Contributing to broader national decarbonisation efforts** by accelerating the phase-out of high-emitting, energy-intensive assets.

Currently, Kenya has managed to secure only $4.6 billion for climate finance, of which only 40% has gone to the energy sector, falling significantly short of its annual target of $3.2 billion. This funding gap highlights the challenge of securing enough capital for the transition. According to The Paris Agreement, achieving the global climate goals will require scaling up investments in green technologies, particularly in sectors like agriculture that are crucial to Kenya's economy.

By unlocking green finance at scale, Kenya can not only help agro-processors transition to sustainable practices but also contribute to the global effort to mitigate climate change. Through the pilot programme, MESPT and FSD Kenya hope to create a model that will encourage financial institutions to invest more heavily in the agricultural sector's green transition.

This energy transition mechanism pilot presents a valuable opportunity to demonstrate that climate-conscious finance can be both accessible and profitable for agri-processors. The hope is that, once the model proves successful, financial institutions will adopt it and scale it further, creating a lasting impact on the agriculture sector and the environment.

Ultimately, finance will play a crucial role in this transition. By effectively allocating capital, financial institutions can help drive the adoption of sustainable practices and promote environmental responsibility. The success of this pilot could serve as a turning point in how the financial sector in Kenya and beyond responds to the needs of agri-businesses seeking to transition to a greener future.

In conclusion, through innovation and collaboration, Kenya can overcome the barriers to accessing green finance and take bold steps toward achieving its decarbonisation goals while fostering a more sustainable agricultural sector. This energy transition mechanism pilot is just the beginning of what could be a larger movement towards a sustainable economy. What room is there, if at all, for failure?

> ***Currently, Kenya has managed to secure only $4.6 billion for climate finance, of which only 40% has gone to the energy sector, falling significantly short of its annual target of $3.2 billion.***

FSD Kenya's work on agriculture and processing finance aims to accelerate development of value-adding finance to catalyse increased production, productivity and profitability of female smallholder farmers, agricultural traders, and processors.

Click here to access more stories, blogs and publications related to FSD Kenya's agriculture and processing finance work

Boresha Boma: Piloting a financial product for climate-smart home improvements targeting rural communities in Kenya



Given that 61.4% of Kenya's population is rural, promoting climate friendly home improvement solutions in rural areas is of importance to Kenya's development.

FSD Kenya partnered with KFS (K-Rep Fedha Services) in this work – KFS is an umbrella organisation that provides technical professional management services and oversight for community based financial institutions in rural Kenya. KFS's umbrella currently supports 33 Financial Sector Associations (FSAs) with a membership base of 375,000 people.

From 2023 to date, KFS and FSD Kenya have partnered to diagnose, co-design and implement a pilot that will support their members to access credit for improved cook stoves, rainwater harvesting, sanitation and housing units. A demand analysis was undertaken in five areas which clearly showed the need for climate-friendly housing solutions to support a move away from the commonly used practices which damaged the environment and provided poor housing conditions including the use of burnt bricks, high use of firewood, inefficient adoption of rainwater harvesting etc.

Two of the five FSAs where the customers had a higher ability to repay, were selected for a pilot. Local members of the financial institutions were engaged in the product vision, and local artisans were trained to build with climate friendly technologies including sand cement blocks and soil stabilised blocks. Loan product development was done in conjunction with input from borrowers, staff and management of the financial institutions and KFS.

Key accomplishments include a high-level awareness and positive attitude towards the new technologies being promoted due to inclusive stakeholder engagement. The loan product branded as 'Boresha Boma' ranges from as small as KShs 5,000 to KShs 600,000, with tenors of 12 months to 60 months depending on the home improvement solution pursued. The loan products allow for improved cookstoves, rainwater harvesting, toilets and shower structures, and housing structures to be built incrementally or at one go, depending on the household's needs and ability to repay.

As of Dec 2024, five months after the launch of the pilot loan product, KShs 2,595,000 had been disbursed in 45 loans at an average loan size of KShs 56,400. 46% of borrowers are women. In addition, 33 artisans (mix of experienced and polytechnic students) have been trained with the ability to create the blocks and undertake the home improvements. A catalogue of all the housing solutions has been developed and disseminated freely.

While these technologies have been available for decades, uptake has been very low as previous attempts focused on providing training on the technology itself. In this pilot, FSD Kenya and KFS took an end-to-end value chain approach. The demand survey, training of artisans and financial institutions and staff, and product development was done in conjunction with KFS, the financial institutions staff, members of the financial institutions and an experienced alternative building technology expert. FSD Kenya also provided a risk capital loan fund, to allow FSAs to lend for Boresha Boma products, as these are longer term loans than their core portfolio and would tie up the institutions' capital. Additional technical capacity is being provided to help the trained artisans create bills of quantities for each respective loan request, as many of the housing products need to be tailored to the specific household's existing conditions and ability to pay.

> ***As of Dec 2024, five months after the launch of the pilot loan product, KShs 2,595,000 had been disbursed in 45 loans at an average loan size of KShs 56,400. 46% of borrowers are women.***

Based on the success of the pilot (loan uptake and repayment), KFS expects to be able to recover this capital from the two pilot FSAs and then revolve it to other FSAs who are interested in this product. The need for improved rural housing is significant, and will result in strong economic, environmental, health and social benefits. This pilot can provide insights on supporting rural housing ambitions of The Affordable Housing Fund.



FSD Kenya's work on affordable housing finance aims to facilitate the creation of appropriate financial solutions that will enable improved access to decent and affordable shelter with associated infrastructure/services.

Click here to access more stories, blogs and publications related to FSD Kenya's affordable housing finance work.

Improving maternal and neonatal health outcomes through a value-based care approach



Kenya's Vision 2030 and the current administration's policy agenda prioritises universal health coverage, aiming to ensure all Kenyans receive the highest quality of care.

Despite the progress attained in the past few decades, maternal and neonatal health (MNH) remains a key healthcare challenge in Kenya. The latest data shows that Kenya's maternal mortality ratio (MMR) was 530 deaths per 100,000 live births in 2020 (World Health Organisation) and the neonatal mortality rate 21 deaths per 1,000 live births (Kenya Demographic and Health Survey, 2022). Kenya's maternal and neonatal mortality rates are significantly above the global averages despite the national Linda Mama programme and other efforts.

The ambition in addressing the maternal and neonatal mortality has been primarily to increase the volume of available and consumed healthcare, that is, building more healthcare facilities, training and hiring more nurses and doctors, prescribing and funding more medicine. However, based on research and evidence the quality of care is now the main driver of successful healthcare delivery and improved health outcomes.

> ***The latest data shows that Kenya's maternal mortality ratio (MMR) was 530 deaths per 100,000 live births in 2020 (World Health Organisation) and the neonatal mortality rate 21 deaths per 1,000 live births (Kenya Demographic and Health Survey, 2022).***

FSD Kenya's health finance work aims to facilitate and advocate for value adding finance that enables improved health and financial resilience to health shocks for women and households.

FSD Kenya has partnered with Britam Holdings Limited and the FSD Network Gender Collaborative Programme, to design and pilot a MNH value-based care programme which was launched in May 2024. The design

incorporated insights from a User journeys study which sought to understand the pain points and how access to quality care could be improved.

Value-based care is a healthcare approach that focuses on delivering high-quality care at a lower cost by prioritising outcomes that matter most to patients. Its goal is to shift the healthcare system from a fee-for-service model, which incentivises providers to perform more procedures and services, to one that rewards providers for achieving better health outcomes for patients.

The expectation was that the pilot would improve maternal and neonatal health outcomes for the participating households, scalability of Britam's AfyaTele health insurance solution, and cost effectiveness for healthcare providers. Thus far, Britam has partnered with 31 healthcare facilities within Nairobi and its environs for provision of care and Jacaranda Health. Jacranda Health's PROMPTs, an artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled digital health service two-way SMS exchange, empowers women to seek care at the right time and place, and gives them greater agency in the health system. The system also collects feedback from the participants which has been useful in monitoring and improving the quality of care.

Eight months down the line, the pilot had reached over 1,100 expectant mothers and led to better MNH health outcomes above the national figures such as 29% caesarean sections and 61% spontaneous normal delivery (compared to 53% and 45% as per Kenya Health Information System), respectively. Generally, the mothers are happy with the care received under the programme, with a net promoter score of 9.4.

The value-based care approach presents an opportunity for providing quality healthcare at scale. It is our hope that the pilot will provide valuable learning, and this approach can adopted beyond MNH within Britam and by other players in the market, including the public health sector.



FSD Kenya's work on health finance aims to facilitate and advocate for value adding finance that enables improved health and financial resilience to health shocks for women and households

Click here to access more stories, blogs and publications related to FSD Kenya's health finance work.

FinAccess 2024: Opportunities to shape insights for an inclusive future



The 2024 FinAccess Household Survey, the seventh edition, marks a key milestone for Kenya and FSD Kenya. As Kenya advances its development agenda and aligns with global financial inclusion goals, FinAccess provides an important evidence base for market actors to drive meaningful change. FinAccess 2024 also serves as a foundation for FSD Kenya's strategy design, offering critical insights to shape programming for the next four years as FSD develops its new strategy.

Collaborative effort to drive impact

Led by the Central Bank of Kenya (CBK) in partnership with FSD Kenya and the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics (KNBS), FinAccess 2024 saw increased engagement and financial contributions from key financial sector regulators: the Sacco Societies Regulatory Authority (SASRA); the Insurance Regulatory Authority (IRA); the Capital Markets Authority (CMA); the Retirement Benefit Authority (RBA); and the Kenya Deposit Insurance Corporation(KDIC).

The 2024 survey also attracted financial contributions and active participation from partners such as the Alliance for Financial Inclusion, Safaricom, Equity Bank, the International Fund for Agricultural Development, and UN Women. The strong involvement of UN Women underscored the central role of gender in inclusive finance, and the upcoming FinAccess gender report will further highlight these insights following the successful launch of the main FinAccess Report on 5th December 2024.

The launch was graced by the Cabinet Secretary, The National Treasury and Economic planning and the chief executives of financial sector regulators. Beyond the main report, the partnership will produce sector-specific analyses covering SACCOs, banking, pension, insurance, and county-level insights among other topics. These outputs will provide regulators, policymakers, and private sector players with actionable data to advance inclusive finance and strengthen Kenya's financial ecosystem.

> ***The 2024 survey also attracted financial contributions and active participation from partners such as the Alliance for Financial Inclusion, Safaricom, Equity Bank, the International Fund for Agricultural Development, and UN Women.***

Strengthening appreciation of FinAccess insights through firsthand engagement

The survey implementation process brought together regulators, policymakers, and private sector players, engaging them from questionnaire design to fieldwork and analysis. FSD Kenya's staff actively participated during the pilot phase, testing the survey instrument and observing field interviews. These firsthand experiences deepened the team's understanding of the realities faced by underserved populations, contextualising the challenges and realities they face, ensuring the insights from FinAccess impactfully inform FSD Kenya's upcoming strategy.

Informing FSD Kenya's upcoming strategy

As FSD Kenya embarks on designing its next strategy, FinAccess will remain central to shaping priorities and interventions. In 2025, a dedicated team session will further explore the data, further ensuring its integration into FSD's programming. With sector-specific reports and county analyses forthcoming, the insights will continue to inform other targeted interventions for various stakeholders, from gender-responsive financial policies to innovative market solutions as well as the proposed National Financial Inclusion Strategy (NFIS).

The future of FinAccess and role in achieving SDG's and vision 2030

The increasing interest from stakeholders highlights FinAccess' growing value as a tool for driving inclusive finance. As Kenya progresses towards achieving sustainable development and Vision 2030 goals, FinAccess will remain a cornerstone of evidence-based decision-making, equipping policymakers and market players with the insights needed to bridge financial gaps and empower communities.

It is exciting to look forward to further exploration of the FinAccess datasets and anticipate exciting opportunities to strengthen inclusive finance and shape a more equitable financial future for all Kenyans!



Click here to access the full report and other resources related to the 2024 FinAccess Household Survey

5 Blogs and publications

#	Title	Authors	Date
1.	Enhancing quality of care for women through a pharmacy trade credit facility	Wanza Mbole, Nancy Atello, Gladys Kuria, and James Awandu	22nd January
2.	Opportunities and practice of green finance in Kenya	Anzetse Were	20th February
3.	Segmenting the financial services market for women in Kenya	Lukania Geraldine Makunda, Amrik Heyer, Wanza Mbole, Nancy Atello, Jessica Breier, Aviva Phillips, and Jessica Smith	11th March
4.	The financial journeys of young women and men in Kenya.	Amrik Heyer, Jessica Breier, Aviva Phillips, and Jessica Smith	11th March
5.	Inspiring inclusion through women's access to financial services and products	Nancy Atello, Seeta Shah, Jared Ochieng, Collins Baswony and Wanza Mbole	11th March
6.	County green finance assessment demonstrates the green finance opportunity at county level in Kenya	Milkah Chebii, Tamara Cook, Anzetse Were	24th April
7.	Driving change: Hello Tractor and ABERA	Duncan Oyaro	20th May
8.	Positioning affordable and backyard rental housing as a key target in Kenya's affordable housing programme (draft findings)		27th May
9.	Medium term plan for Kenya's financial services sector	Francis Gwer	27th May
10.	Agent interoperability: Steps towards an interoperable agent network	Juliet Mburu	27th May
11.	The green finance opportunity in Kenya	Anzetse Were	27th May
12.	Understanding the role of Farmer Service Centres in agriculture and processing finance	Jared Ochieng, Duncan Oyaro	27th May
13.	Makueni Land Information Management System	Seeta Shah, Lucy Owano	27th May
14.	What's Ailing Start-up Tech Firms in Africa?	Anzetse Were	12th July
15.	Dynamics and future potential of crypto-asset markets in Africa	Anzetse Were	20th June
16.	Organising smallholders through Farmer Service Centres: What role can finance play?	Jared Ochieng, Duncan Oyaro, Carol Matiko, Aviva Phillips, Jessica Breier	10th July
17.	Dynamics and outlook of crypto-asset markets in Africa	Anzetse Were	10th July
18.	FinAccess 2024 is here	Tamara Cook, Lukania Makunda, Sharon Juma, Amrik Heyer	17th July
19.	FSD Kenya, CIS Kenya and Creditinfo CRB launch findings from study on Kenya's credit market landscape.	Francis Gwer, Kamau Kunyiha, Jared Getenga	5th August

#	Title	Authors	Date
20.	The intrigues and dilemmas in delivering value adding financial solutions for dairy smallholder women farmers.	Wanjiku Karanja, Jared Ochieng	7th August
21.	Launch of warehouse receipt financing feasibility study findings	Jared Ochieng, Duncan Oyaro	26th August
22.	The Africa Green Climate Finance National Designated Authorities Network High Level Forum	Anzetse Were	26th August
23.	Understanding pregnancy journeys for value-based care	Wanza Mbole, Nancy Atello, Carol Matiko, Elizabeth Opondo, Julie Zollmann, Joel Lehmann	4th September
24.	For their mutual benefit - Kenya's SACCOs history and prospects	Amrik Heyer, Wanza Mbole, Radha Upadhyaya, Justin Willis	10th September
25.	Insights on policy leadership in green and climate finance	Anzetse Were	23rd September
26.	Warehouse receipt financing feasibility study	Jared Ochieng, Duncan Oyaro	27th September
27.	Building resilient innovation ecosystems in Kenya	Parijat Chakrabarti, Amrik Heyer, James Kashangaki, Duncan Oyaro and Jared Ochieng	15th October
28.	SACCOs have the potential to play a bigger role for Kenya's remittance inflows, but regulatory and operational challenges stand in the way, the study finds	Juliet Mburu, Lukania Geraldine Makunda and Collins Baswony	16th October
29.	Takeaways from the Financial Inclusion Conference and Investor Expo 2024 (FinCon2024)	Lukania Geraldine Makunda, Seeta Shah, Amrik Heyer and Sarah Makena	22nd October
30.	Navigating challenges and opportunities for MSMEs in Kenya: Insights from the 13th Annual Banking Research Conference	Lukania Geraldine Makunda and Adah Mukubi	29th October
31.	FSD Kenya at the African Investment Conference London (AFSIC)	Sarah Makena	29th October
32.	County green investment facility up and running	Sarah Makena and Anzetse Were	4th November
33.	The macroeconomic environment and the pension sector in Kenya	Anzetse Were	12th November
34.	The role of SACCOs and cooperatives in Kenya's real economy: Challenges, innovations, and future prospects	Duncan Oyaro	13th November
35.	The impact of Covid-19 on credit conditions in Kenya	Amrik Heyer and Paul Gubbins	27th November
36.	2024 FinAccess Household Survey summary infographic	Communications	3rd December
37.	2024 FinAccess Household Survey: Key insights into Kenya's financial landscape	Communications	3rd December
38.	2024 FinAccess Household Survey topline report	Communications	3rd December

6 Events and webinars

Event name
Launch of the county green finance assessment report
FSD Kenya at the Financing Agriculture Sustainably Conference (FINAS 2024)
Webinar: Creating an equitable contract and model for tenant purchase scheme and linking the proceeds to an income REIT
Launch of findings from the Kenya credit market landscape report
Warehouse receipt financing feasibility study dissemination event
The 8th AgriFin Learning Event (ALE)
Launch of findings from the SACCOs as remittance providers in Kenya study
Navigating open finance webinar - Key insights and opportunities for Kenya's financial sector
FSD Kenya at COP29
Launch of the 2024 FinAccess household survey topline findings report
County green investment facility up and running

7 Financials

Financial Sector Deepening Trust Kenya
Income Statement - Unaudited
For the year ended 31st December 2024

	2024	2023 Audited
	KShs Millions**	KShs Millions**
INCOME		
Grants	1,105	818
Other Income	14	8
Finance income	44	5
Unrealised foreign exchange gains	-	234
Total Income	**1,164**	**1,065**
EXPENDITURE		
Project Expenses	974	722
Administrative expenses	132	143
Other expenses	360	-
Total expenditure	**1,466**	**865**
Unrealised foreign exchange losses	210	-
Total costs	**1,676**	**865**
Surplus/(Deficit) for the year	**(512)**	**200**

1. Finance income includes interest earned on FSD funds

8 Governance



Anne Mutahi
Independent member (Chair)



Andy Baker
Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office



Anna Wallace
Gates Foundation



Ronald Inyangala
Government of Kenya



Paul Muthaura
Independent member



Amani M'Bale
Observer,
Gates Foundation



Marie Ottosson
Observer,
Swedish International Development Cooperation Agency (Sida)



Joan Karanja
Observer,
Swedish International Development Cooperation Agency (Sida)



Peter Githongo
Trustee, BDO Kenya



Clifford Ah Chip
Trustee, BDO Kenya

9 FSD Kenya **team**



Amrik Heyer
Senior research advisor



Anzetse Were
Senior economist and green finance advisor



Boniface Mbithi
Procurement specialist



Brian Cheruiyot
IT Manager



Collins Baswony
Communications lead



Duncan Oyaro
Enterprise specialist



Esther Muriithi
Finance and grant manager



Esther Murugi
Communications officer



Fausto Njeru
Finance and risk controller



Francis Gwer
Senior policy specialist



Geraldine Lukania Makunda
Data and insights specialist



Hilda Githaiga
Project manager, Policy and infrastructure



James Kashangaki
Chief programme officer



Jared Ochieng
Senior agriculture finance specialist



Juliet Mburu
Senior digital financial infrastructure specialist



Lucy Owano
Project manager- Affordable housing



Lydia Kamande
Office assistant/housekeeper



Lydiah Kioko
Head of operations



Michael Njeru
Project manager - Green finance



Nancy Atello
Project manager - Health finance



Partick Macharia
Affordable housing specialist



Samuel Gicho
Office assistant/Driver



Sarah Makena
Senior green finance specialist



Seeta Shah
Senior Affordable housing specialist



Sharon Juma
Data analyst



Sylvia Nyamai
Procurement officer



Tamara Cook
Chief executive officer



Valerie Mukuna
Results lead



Wanjiku Karanja
Livelihoods specialist



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